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Ways of Being Male: Masculinities as Allegories in Yu Hua's *Brothers*

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ABSTRACT

This essay uses masculinity as a theoretical lens through which to read and interpret the important social and historical changes that have shaped China over the last four decades of the twentieth century. Yu Hua's novel *Brothers* is a classic example in which masculinities serve as allegories for the collapse of traditional Chinese values and the rise of a market-driven ethos from the late 1970s onward. While predatory masculinity, embodied in protagonist Baldy Li, fits in perfectly well with a newly emerging market economy, soft masculinity, manifested in protagonist Song Gang, is deeply nostalgic and harks back to a self-contained agrarian culture of Confucian China. Ultimately, masculinity becomes an intriguing and contested site not only of competing values but also of contrasting socio-economic systems. One can argue that neither the ideologically rigid Maoist system nor the unbridled market economy allows for the possibility of an ideal masculinity. Like morality, masculinity is compromised and eventually becomes a casualty in China's relentless change and transformation. As such, the notion of masculinity serves as an interesting theoretical perspective from which to ponder China's historical trajectory, its modernization process and the gains and losses associated with it.

Introduction

Published in two volumes in 2005 and 2006, Yu Hua's *Xiong Di* (Brothers) became an instant bestseller in China and was subsequently translated into many foreign languages in the years that followed.[1] Despite selling more than one million copies, *Brothers* received mixed reviews in China, criticized mostly for its vulgarity, absurdity and obscenity.[2] What attracts the critics' attention are the grotesque narrative style and the so-called "revolt in language" (*yuyan de fanpan*), as is often the case with Yu Hua's novels (Li, Zhang, and Wang). The novel, however, has been acclaimed by Anglophone reviewers as an exceptional masterpiece, a compelling satire of an increasingly materialistic consumer society, with the combination of broad caricature and earnest realism.[3] Described as "a big-spirited comedy of society running amok in modern China" (1), the novel which is situated against the radical historical shift from the Cultural Revolution (1966–1976) to a market-based economy during the Reform Era, has largely been read as a social satire. Even a gendered interpretation is intricately intertwined with the politics of China. As the translators of the novel persuasively argue: "The object of this narrative gaze is often the female body [. . .] but just as often it is the Chinese body politic – the deeply schizophrenic national history that Yu Hua has lived through, and to which he attempts to give life in the pages of the novel" (VIII).

The present essay builds upon these insights to offer a gendered reading that looks beyond the female body to focus on males and their masculine traits. The legitimacy of such a reading can be partially glimpsed through the novel's title. *Brothers* recounts the life experiences of Baldy Li and Song

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Gang, who become stepbrothers during their childhood as Li's mother marries Song's father. Spanning almost four decades, the novel's raw, often grotesque, narrative traces the brothers' dramatic life trajectories from the brutal years of the Cultural Revolution through the economic reform to the beginning of the 21st century, a period of tremendous historical transition. Inseparable as children, the two brothers eventually part ways in their mid-ages, with Li successfully turning himself into the richest business tycoon and Song ending up destitute and downtrodden. Li and Song, as the present essay argues, represent two drastically different ways of being male in China's historical transformations in the latter half of the twentieth century.

In reading *Brothers*, this essay draws from the burgeoning field of Masculinity Studies, employing theoretical perspectives that have not so far been considered by critics of Yu Hua's novels. Masculinity studies have emerged as a serious academic discipline in the past decades. As with femininity, masculinity has now been recognized as a constructed concept, rather than an innate or inherent category (Gilmore; Connell; Kimmel). Manhood, rather than static or timeless, is historical, constructed in relation to "a set of 'others'" (Kimmel 182). Although masculinity is not the exclusive domain of men or manhood,[4] it is usually in the context of men's/manhood studies that masculinity is taken as a serious object of inquiry. Academic studies of gender in modern and contemporary Chinese fiction have largely focused on women and femininity (Chow; Liu; Sang; Zhu). As Evans and Strauss note: "narratives on masculinity . . . are notably absent, in part reflecting how gender in academic studies of China is still largely associated with the study of women" (825). This imbalance is being redressed by an emerging body of scholarly works on masculinity in modern and contemporary Chinese society, history and culture (Hinsch; Hird; Huang; Louie; Lu; Pang and Wong; Song; Vitiello; Xiao; Yang). Concomitantly, studies of masculinity in Chinese literature have also started to emerge (Zamperini; Zhong).

The present essay uses masculinity as a theoretical lens through which to read and interpret the important social and historical changes that have shaped China over the last four decades of the twentieth century. The drastically different fates of the male protagonists in *Brothers* signify the collapse of traditional Chinese values and the rise of a predatory and market-driven ethos. Through the figure of Baldy Li, Yu Hua delineates for us, not without sarcasm, the kind of masculinity that helps one flourish and thrive in turn-of-the-century China. In stark contrast is a radically different kind of masculinity, embodied in the figure of Song Gang. If the former fits in perfectly well with the ethos of a newly emerging market economy and its morals in the 1980s, the latter is deeply nostalgic and harks back to a self-contained agrarian culture of the Chinese past. These two models – designated, respectively, as predatory masculinity and soft masculinity – signal drastically different fates of the Chinese male subject from the late 1970s to the early 2000s. Ultimately, masculinities serve as allegories for China's radical historical changes, and the diverging fates of the brothers bespeak the author's trenchant critique as China's shift restructured both the economy and gender ideals.

The Cultural Revolution and the Destruction of the Patriarchal Ideal

Brothers is deliberately structured to span two drastically different historical moments in contemporary China: the Maoist times and the Reform Era. The novel's construction of the two models of masculinity in the Reform Era is predicated on its destruction of the patriarchal ideal during Mao's Cultural Revolution, a class-based revolutionary era characterized by violence and brutality. One may argue that *Brothers* is an interesting novel for exploring Chinese masculinities largely because it showcases the very process through which Chinese masculinities have undergone from the tumultuous Cultural Revolutionary years of the 1960s to a market-based economy in the last two decades of the twentieth century.

The Culture Revolution is a fanatic era, one of the many instances in human history where large groups of people fell victim to certain ideologies and went crazy in their single-minded pursuit of goals and actions which in retrospect were ridiculous, insane and even unpardonable. The era's chaos, marked by public denunciations, ideological fanaticism, and the erosion of familial and moral bonds,

results in socio-political and economic regression. Yu Hua's fictional engagement with this part of contemporary Chinese history is astounding. The episodes of public shaming and public struggles in the novel portray a chaotic moment when both social order and conventional gender norms are dismantled. This can be glimpsed through the fate of the patriarchal ideal, embodied in the figure of Song Fanping, Song Gang's biological father and Baldy Li's stepfather. Tall, strong and handsome, Song Fanping, who remarries Baldy Li's mother Li Lan, appears only in the first volume of the novel which details the ordeals of the reorganized family in the frantic years of the 1960s.[5] A former soldier, Song Fanping, with his physical robustness and moral goodness, is regarded and remembered as "a real man" by the people in Liu Town, exhibiting what might be termed "ideal masculinity" in the modern Chinese imagination. In moral terms, nonetheless, such an ideal is deeply reminiscent of the traditional Confucian masculinity embodied in the archetype of *junzi* (gentleman or the noble person), the cultivated, moral and benevolent male in whose image Song is portrayed. Since Song is in a family line of landlords, he is locked up in a detainment warehouse where he suffers every torment and abuse imaginable. With his physical strength and moral integrity, he becomes an easy target for the Red Guards who kept a consistent eye on him in the warehouse. Maltreated, humiliated, and beaten up numerous times by the Red Guards, Song still holds his head high and never bows down to the abusers. Nor does he ever utter a word of complaint. His pride, tenacity and unyielding resilience earns him tremendous respect from his stepson Baldy Li who would sigh while raising his thumb: "What a real man" (117).

"Real man," however, is a curse at a time when traditional notions of gender were being dismantled. Scholars have noted an intriguing phenomenon during and briefly after the Maoist era known as *yinsheng yangshuai* ("the rise of the feminine and the decline of the masculine"). The women's liberation movements in the Maoist era witnessed decades of female masculinization in the name of male-female equality. Maoist China sought to eliminate all identity differences other than the category of class. The Maoist ideology of gender equality, as Dai Jinghua notes, "camouflaged a socialist impasse that did not so much emancipate as masculinize women" (Wang and Barlow 8). The Cultural Revolution, it is widely agreed, "represented a period when both feminism and femininity were rejected" (Honig 256). What is often much less noted is that when women were being masculinized, traditional notions of masculinity were often despised, especially during the fanatic era of the Cultural Revolution when the personal was too often usurped and displaced by the political. Male masculinity, especially the kind associated with the Confucian gentry ideal, was prone to be debunked and attacked, all in the service of the nationalist cause which valorizes class-based and class-conscious revolutionary ideologies. It was not until the 1980s when "the decline of the masculine" gave rise to a crisis of masculinity that the idea of "real men" (*nanzihan* in Chinese) began to be regarded as worthy again.

Despite being plunged into the abyss of misery, Song Fanping, as a real man, still tries his best to protect his family as he himself is thoroughly beaten down. He presents a moral and stoic image of sanity and silence in the midst of insanity and the senseless. A loyal and devoted husband, he shows unceasing love to his wife until death. In order for Li Lan not to worry while receiving her migraine treatment in Shanghai, Song continues to write his wife letters after his detainment, filling them with passion and energy without telling her what has really happened to him. Until the day he dies, she has not the slightest idea what her husband has been through. A caring father, Song tries hard to protect his sons the way he protects his wife. Even as his dislocated left arm becomes increasingly swollen, he tells the boys that he is only acting. His resilience and tenacity stay with him to his last minute, but Song also has a soft and vulnerable side, shown only as a tender father moved by what his sons have done for him. Song Fanping's manliness and masculinity, as can be expected, only guaranteed his death in the historical nightmare. After all, in the demise of the masculine individual subject lies the final victory of the abusive power of the state. The tragedy of Song Fanping may therefore be read as a fierce attack on the Cultural Revolution itself.[6] In her memorable memoir *Life and Death in Shanghai*, Nien Cheng offers a searing indictment of the Cultural Revolution through her detailed account of its dehumanizing effect. Yu Hua shows that the Revolution is not only dehumanizing; it is also de-masculinizing. Song's death signifies the fall of the patriarchal ideal that embodies both

physical soundness and moral integrity. Admittedly, Song's martyrdom is the direct and unambiguous result of the Revolution's brutality, one might wonder, however, whether or not such masculinity can survive the realities of a deeply flawed human world. Eventually, the fall of the patriarchal ideal is not only a vehement critique and blatant exposure of the Cultural Revolution as a historical nightmare but also a potent reminder of the vulnerability of ideal masculinity as well as a heart-wrenching interrogation of its fate in the real world.

Protagonists Baldy Li and Song Gang grew up in the zeal of the Cultural Revolutionary era. Their relationship during this period of time is shaped by poverty, scarcity and humiliation due to their father's identity. As they grew into their teenage years, Song Gang began to exhibit a type of masculinity quite akin to his father's, specifically in moral terms, while Baldy Li, even as a teenager, was already found to be unruly and opportunistic. In an opening scene of the novel, the reader learns that Li, now Liu Town's premier tycoon, has had a notorious past. As a 14-year-old boy, Li gets caught peeping at women's bottoms in a public pit toilet, exactly what his own biological father did on the day Li was born. His father, however, accidentally fell into the cesspool and drowned. Li, who is caught on the spot, is paraded through the streets and becomes the joke of the town, which deeply shames his mother who has already been disgraced by the infamous death of her husband. The obscene portrayals can be read as the author's mockery and critique of the Maoist era. In the name of moral purism and asceticism, the Maoist era treated sexuality as a forbidden topic. In the context of the Cultural Revolution, sexuality is closely linked to a bourgeois mind-set. As Evans notes, in this context, matters related to sex and sexuality were seen "either as the shameful expression of a warped mind or as evidence of bourgeois individualism" (1–2). It is therefore understandable that the vulgar scenes of sexuality portrayed in the novel, which have been recognized as one of the author's hallmarks, place Yu Hua neatly among those who are known to write to challenge the dominant CCP ideologies and discourses in a way that would amuse the average reader in today's China but certainly would not, to echo Howard Goldblatt, amuse Chairman Mao.

The fall of the patriarchal ideal opened up a space for new possibilities. Could these new possibilities live up to the fallen ideal? As the 1980s drew near, Blady Li and Song Gang grew into very different young men, exhibiting drastically different masculine traits that eventually led them onto very different paths in life. As the analyses that follow will show, masculinity in the post-Revolution Reform Era can be viewed as a contested site of competing sets of values. In *Masculinity Besieged?* Zhong Xueping contends that Chinese masculinity has been in crisis, arguing that the Cultural Revolution and its aftermath intensified this crisis. I am tempted to argue that the two models of masculinity in *Brothers* point to the very nature of that crisis. Embodied, respectively, in Baldy Li and Song Gang whose fates turn out to be drastically different, the two models reveal important facets of Chinese historical realities that could not afford to be ignored.

Violence, Sex, and Power: Predatory Masculinity as the Hegemonic Model and the Ascent of Baldy Li

R. W. Connell writes, "'Masculinity,' to the extent the term can be briefly defined at all, is simultaneously a place in gender relations, the practices through which men and women engage that place in gender, and the effects of these practices in bodily experience, personality and culture" (Connell *Masculinities* 71). According to Michael Kimmel, masculinity is a relational construct and is to be reconstructed, reasserted, or redefined in relation to changing social and economic conditions and the changing position of women in society (Kimmel 153). In a given society at a particular time, one form of masculinity tends to assume the dominant position over others. According to Connell, the culturally exalted masculinity may be defined as hegemonic masculinity, which is "the configuration of gender practice which embodies the currently accepted answer to the problem of the legitimacy of patriarchy, which guarantees (or is taken to guarantee) the dominant position of men and the subordination of women" (*Masculinities* 77).[7] The concept of "hegemony" derives from Antonio Gramsci's analysis of class relations, and refers to the cultural dynamic by which a group claims and maintains a leading

position in social life. The chauvinistic Baldy Li in *Brothers* exemplifies the hegemonic model of masculinity in the 1980s and 90s Chinese context. As can be seen, Yu Hua's treatment of this type of masculinity in the novel is deeply satirical. The satirical effect is achieved mainly through grotesque exaggerations of Li's vulgarity and audacity and their connection with power in different terms.

The novel opens with the end: Baldy Li, Liu Town's premier tycoon, plans to spend twenty million U.S. dollars to purchase a ride on a Russian Federation space shuttle for a tour of outer space. The novel then flashes back to the end of the Cultural Revolution which ushers in the beginning of the Reform Era, pivoting to a China which finds itself in the midst of reforms. The reader is now transported to a world of consumption, money-making, and excess. Before going into business, Li is a director of a state-owned company. He is among the first group of people in China who have the guts to give up a secure and stable job – the so-called "iron bowl" – in favor of potential opportunities in the business world. In the 1980s when China was beginning to open up, the first wave of economic rewards were reaped by dare-goers such as Li. Starting out from scratch, the nasty Li, after years of struggle, becomes the town's most successful tycoon, accruing mass fortunes with his business savvy. In the vibrant atmosphere of the 1980s when economic activities were bourgeoning, audacity and unscrupulousness aided significantly in the realm of business. The predatory type of masculinity emerges, where prestige and manhood are tied to conspicuous financial success and sexual prowess. Li embodies this new type of masculinity in its crudest, most parodic form.

The ascent in financial terms turns Li into a nationwide celebrity. Never hesitating to cash in on his fame, Li proposes to organize a beauty pageant – the infamous Inaugural National Virgin Beauty Competition[8]– where self-proclaimed virgins across the nation come to Liu Town to be evaluated and graded for their physical beauty by male judges. This event is perhaps the best testament to Li's male chauvinism that casts women as sexual objects to be preyed upon. The following conversation is taken from a press conference held in publicity for the competition:

> Another reporter asked, "What will be the entry requirements for prospective contestants?"
>
> PR Liu responded as if reciting a tongue twister: "They must be beautiful and elegant, healthy and graceful, sociable and mature, accomplished and modest, respectful of elders and loving of the young, pure and chaste, and with no prior sexual experience."
>
> The reporter then asked, "Will those women who may have torn their hymens while doing sports be permitted to compete? And how about those whose hymens have been breached as a result of sexual violence? Will they be allowed to participate?"
>
> PR Liu answered, "Our Boss Li has the greatest respect for the two categories of women you mention and has given a great deal of thought to the question you have raised, losing appetite and sleep over the matter. In the end, however, he has decided to sacrifice those women to help preserve the integrity and authority of the competition as a whole. He explicitly asked, however, that I use this news conference to pay tribute to those women and exhort all Chinese men to lavish them with love and attention." (477–478)

Packaged as a tribute to women and their virtues, the competition, a blatantly patriarchal project, reveals the hegemonic nature of the masculinity manifested by the likes of Li and the ways in which hegemonic masculinity works to legitimate the subordination of women. Indeed, the early scene of teenage Li caught peeping women's bottoms already points to the vulgarity of the masculinity embodied in our protagonist. Women for Baldy Li only serve as a spectacle, an object to be looked on and sought after. As he goes on to pursue Lin Hong, Li turns her into a public spectacle as well when he sends five boys hollering in unison "Baldy Li wants to court you" (243).

As Connell reminds us, however, "'[h]egemonic masculinity' is always constructed in relation to various subordinated masculinities as well as in relation to women" (*Gender and Power* 183). Li's masculinity is displayed not only through his lack of respect for women, but also through his condescending attitude toward his male counterparts, most notably his brother Song Gang Li is overly confident, assertive and chauvinistic, whereas Song is hesitant and self-effacing; Li is deeply self-oriented, egoistic and looks only after his own interests,

whereas Song, a bookish introvert, is at the same time a thoughtful altruist. When Li goes all out to court Lin Hong, he asks Song to be his adviser, and the latter complies, despite thinking and feeling otherwise. Upon learning that Lin is in fact attracted to Song and that the latter also has feelings for her, Li literally demands that Song stay out of the way. Deeply manipulative and calculating, Li would stop at nothing to win over Lin at the expense of his brother. He warns Song not to entertain the idea of being with Lin, to which Song acquiesces. As hegemonic masculinity asserts its power over and against that which is not itself, it is therefore best conceived in relation to alternative forms of masculinity. In many ways, Song is his opposite in the world of men. This applies as much to the way they think and behave as to the way they look. With his dark-rimmed glasses, Song, tall and slim, looks quite scholarly with his handsome face. Li, on the other hand, looks like a bandit even in his Mao suit. A comparison in the novel between Li and Song is revealing: In the eyes of the town elders, Song Gang looks like a civil official (*wen guan*) and Baldy Li a military official (*wu guan*) (220).

The juxtaposition of the *wen-wu* dyad is significant: *wen* and *wu* in themselves represent two opposite poles of masculinity in the pre-modern Confucian culture. *Wen* masculinity (or refined masculinity) is associated with excellent literary performance and cultural attainment, whereas *Wu* masculinity (or martial masculinity) with physical assertiveness, macho power and martial valor. In the aftermath of the Cultural Revolution, the traditional Confucian emphasis on *wen* is clearly eclipsed by the physical robustness of *wu*. An interesting juxtaposition therefore emerges: the strong brawny hero vs. the slim fragile scholar. Known for his aggression, Li is feared by two scholarly men in town: Writer Liu (who later becomes Li's PR spokesman) and Poet Zhao. When his brother Song gets humiliated by Writer Liu, the "extraordinarily strong" Baldy Li teaches the latter a lesson by beating him up (226). When he finishes with Writer Liu who is left to be covered in blood, Li triumphantly announces to the assembled crowd that in the months to come he would give Poet Zhao a good beating: "Poet Zhao is also an intellectual. Please tell him that within the next six months I'll plan to help bring out his true laborer colors, too" (228). The word "laboror" here is an illusion to Maoist discourse where the proletariat laborers are juxtaposed against the bourgeois-minded intellectuals. With his scholarly appearance and demeanor, Song Gang, who has "secretly fallen in love with literature" and even starts to experiment with story writing (221), aligns too easily with *wen* masculinity.

A brief historical overview of the *wen-wu* dyad might lend some interesting perspectives to the hierarchy of masculinities in the novel. Over the lengthy periods in pre-modern China, *wen* assumes primacy over *wu* due to the imperial examination system. However, such preeminence is gradually lost as China starts to modernize itself. In the perceived need to nationalize manhood and modernize the indigenous Chinese masculinity that was deemed in crisis in the early twentieth century, the highly revered traditional *wen* model of masculinity was dismissed as effeminate and unmanly, and displaced subsequently by the Western model of the strong, brawny male. Indeed, in the course of the twentieth century, the criteria for manhood in China were increasingly defined by the modern West: "the critique of Chinese men has been underpinned by the internalisation of the dominant Western notion of masculinity as the universal norm. Chinese men are judged against the myth of the Western macho heroes by the Western standards and are thus labeled effeminate" (Song *The Fragile Scholar* 9). It is in this context that the comparison between Baldy Li and Song Gang becomes extremely revealing.

Although the hierarchy of masculinities is "not a pattern of simple domination based on force" (Connell and Messerschmidt 846), the importance of force and violence, which mark the breach of civilized behavior, is hard to downplay in the hierarchy of masculinities. Much work has been done upon masculinity and power (Brittan, Connell *Gender and Power*), and particularly upon the role played by physical violence in the defense of masculine power and privilege (Connell *Gender and Power* 12–14; Horsfall; Myslik; Hirsch and Kachtan 2). Indeed, the place of force in the hierarchy of masculinities is intriguing. Connell points out that "though 'hegemony' does not refer to ascendancy based on force, it is not incompatible with ascendancy based on force. Indeed, it is common for the two

to go together. [. . .] The connection between hegemonic masculinity and patriarchal violence is close, though not simple" (*Gender and Power* 184).

The importance of force to the concept of masculinity becomes even more prominent in the contemporary Chinese culture given the historical change that has occurred to Chinese masculinity. This can be partially glimpsed through the Chinese male icons that have attained international fame. Bruce Lee, Jackie Chan, Chow Yun Fat and Jet Li – the names of these muscular *kung fu* stars have caught the eyes of millions of movie goers worldwide. Critics have explored the construction of Chinese masculinity and the ways in which this relates to these brawny men's transnational film stardom (Louie, Berry, Yu). Interestingly, *Brothers*, a novel which has achieved international acclaim, also constructs a kind of masculinity that features macho power and physical aggression. Indeed, the novel portrays a world where physical violence and power are inextricably linked to each other. Baldy Li is one example; Blacksmith Tong is another. Known throughout the town for his muscular arms in the years of the Revolution, Blacksmith Tong, a strong and vigorous man just like Li, asserts his power in Liu Town through his robust fists. He, like Li, advances with the times and thrives financially. Power in this case does not originate solely from violence, but it is interwoven with the latter.

Equally linked to power, aside from violence, is male sexual vitality. Baldy Li comes of age in post-Mao China, where a discourse proliferated around the "crisis of masculinity," a direct result of *yinsheng yangshuai* (the rise of the feminine and the decline of the masculine) in Mao's era. As a reaction, sex and sexuality come out into the open in the post-Mao era, serving as a partial answer to the crisis of masculinity. Li's masculinity thrives upon a bold expression of his strong appetite for sex, which is satiated after his huge financial success. As the town's business tycoon, Baldy Li becomes extremely promiscuous, sleeping with numerous women and impressing them with orgasms which seem hard to come by in those days. These women include Lin Hong. Coveted and pursued by Li in her youthful years, Lin Hong, who is deeply attracted to Song and finally marries the latter, fails to remain Song's devoted wife after 20 years of marriage, when Li intrudes as a business tycoon. Lin, now in her 40s, finds herself unable to reject Li, whom she detests as a young girl, succumbing to his financial and sexual powers. When Song is away from town in the hope of making a fortune so that he could give his wife a good life, Li takes advantage of the opportunity and picks up Lin with his black Mercedes.

The marriage between violence and sex seems to make a man more masculine than otherwise, and this is even more true when a man is violent in sex. Violence characterizes Li's sexual intercourse with Lin Hong:

> Then he became a bandit. As Lin Hong stared at him in bewilderment, not having the slightest idea what he was talking about, he grabbed her and stuck his hand into her underpants. He did this lightning-fast, and by the time she realized what had happened, she was already pinned down on the couch with her pants pulled down to her knees. [. . .]
>
> Baldy Li, however, was like a wild animal. Within two minutes he had stripped her naked, and within another minute he had stripped off his own clothes. Lin Hong fought him off with all her strength, while imploringly crying out her husband's name, "Song Gang, Song Gang . . ." (568–69)

Words like "bandit" and "wild animal" underline Baldy Li's manliness, enhanced through his insatiable sexual urge and excellent sexual performance. Li's masculinity, bordering on the animalistic, is reinforced by his ability to satisfy a woman. His sexual encounters with Lin are detailed in the novel, with the latter experiencing countless, unprecedented, mind-blowing orgasms that have never come to her in the 20 years of marriage with her husband: "Lin Hong caressed Baldy Li's body, thinking, *So this is what a real man is like*" (569). Twenty years of marriage fail to help Lin understand what a man is like. One night with Baldy Li does. In this scenario, the reader finally learns that Lin's happy marriage with Song, which everyone in town envies, is not so happy after all: "Her heart longed every day for Song Gang, but her body lusted for Baldy Li. She didn't know how, without the powerful Baldy Li, she would ever make it through the interminable nights. Her desire was like a forest fire, and once it started burning, it was almost impossible to extinguish" (574). It is no coincidence that the two most powerful men in Liu Town – Baldy Li and Blacksmith Tong – seem to be carved from the same mold:

both flaunt their masculinity through violence and physical aggression; both are known for their vigorous sex drive and sexual energy; and both advance with the times and manage to accrue immense fortune in a consumerist society. Even in his sixties, Blacksmith Tong has an insatiable appetite for sex: "The sixty-something Blacksmith Tong was still as randy as a young man, and when he saw a young woman, his eyes would light up like a thief spotting money" (623–624). Physical strength and sexual vitality, however, would not make a man masculine enough in a consumerist society if he is not at the same time wealthy. Hegemonic masculinity in China's market-based economy is inevitably associated with business savvy and financial success, linked eventually to social capital and power. In the years of the economic reform, Blacksmith Tong rides the tide of the reform and transforms himself first into a store owner and then into an owner of the largest supermarket in town, with his fortune surpassed only by Baldy Li. Herein lies the hegemonic nature of predatory masculinity – best perceived through financial, physical and sexual conquest.

Farewell to the Bygone Past: Soft Masculinity, the Loss of Manhood and the Demise of Song Gang

Hegemonic and nonhegemonic masculinities are not reified social types, but relational patterns, which attain their meaning only in relation to each other. This relationship is not one of obliteration or elimination, but one of domination and subordination. Therefore, Baldy Li's hegemonic masculinity – the chauvinistic, predatory type – assumes meaning and significance when contrasted with its opposite – the traditional soft masculinity embodied in his stepbrother Song Gang. Insofar as the Cultural Revolution destroyed the Confucian ideal of manhood, it is only understandable that the traditional Chinese masculinity, where *wen* takes primacy over *wu*, is severely undermined. The hierarchy between a civil official (*wen guan*) and a military official (*wu guan*), where *wen* assumes superiority over *wu*, is now turned on its head, with the military official taking command of the civil official. Indeed, when the elders make the *wen-wu* comment on the two brothers as they walk side by side on the streets, Song, whose literary talents have been recognized by Li, has already been anointed by the latter as his advisor in the earnest pursuit of Lin Hong. Li is effusive in his praise of Song's talents: "Writer Liu and Poet Zhao will be left permanently in the dust" (222). His scholarly appearance and literary talents may place him at the *wen* end of the masculine spectrum, Song's masculinity, however, is not entirely or unambiguously *wen* in nature. As will be made clear in this section, Song embodies all that is obsolete in both *wen* and *wu* masculinities which were highly revered in the pre-modern Confucian society but are increasingly regarded as unmanly, and hence, inadequate in modern times. Through him and his quiet tragedy, Yu Hua mourns the collapse of traditional Chinese values and the passing of Confucian virtues alongside the rise of a predatory and market-driven ethos in contemporary China.

As Li's advisor, Song displays personality traits that are reminiscent of the Confucian scholar. Self-effacing, compliant and extremely loyal, he makes sound judgment of the situation, appraising Lin Hong's reactions level-headedly. His level-headedness is contrasted with Li's self-conceitedness which lead him inevitably to wrong conclusions. Even after Lin has cursed Li, he still stubbornly believes that she likes him:

> The brothers headed home. Baldy Li did not feel at all that he had failed and maintained his proud stride. Song Gang, by contrast, trailed listlessly at his side. He ventured nervously, "I don't think Lin Hong is interested in you."
>
> "That's absurd," Baldy Li responded, adding confidently, "It's simply inconceivable that she would not be interested." (248–49)

Being Li's loyal brother, Song nonetheless continues to offer courting strategies to Li whose requirements he complies with faithfully. When it becomes clear that Lin actually likes Song and wants to ask him out for a date, the latter is hesitant and undecided, with the thought of his brother constantly hanging in the back of his mind and stopping him in his tracks. When he

finally leaves the house with the sole aim to return her the handkerchief, he has to rush to the bridge, "knowing that if he were to run into Baldy Li, all it would take would be for Baldy Li to call out to him, and Song Gang would lose his courage" (282). Devastated by his repeated reminder that Baldy Li is his brother, Lin makes the dramatic move by jumping into the river under the bridge, knowing that Song would save her, which he does. Even after Lin's desperate suicide attempt, however, Song still refuses to make known his feelings for her, leaving her deeply distraught and heart-broken. When he narrates to Li the events of that evening, Li is unmoved by the love between the two, and instead comes up with a master plan to win over Lin's heart. He demands that Song go to Lin's house and hurt her again by telling her to give up all hope, which, to the reader's dismay, Song complies.

The soft and compliant personality of Song reminds the Chinese reader of the traditional *wen* masculinity. It must be noted, however, that soft masculinity in the post-Mao Chinese context needs to be distinguished from the masculinities of the "New Men" in the West during the same period. Whereas the New Man (Rutherford 32–36) may be looked upon as a positive development in the increasingly diversified modern era, soft masculinity in contemporary China is frequently associated with a lingering traditional culture and its backward-looking mind-set.[9] *Wen*, a hallmark of the Confucian scholar, is associated with fragility – not only physically but emotionally as well. Given China's increasing subjugation under the imperialist powers in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, the weak and fragile Chinese male elites were blamed for the nation's demise. Consequently, the imperial examination system, which had held sway over the long historical period giving priority to *wen* masculinity, was made the scapegoat. Concomitantly, since the early twentieth century, the primacy of *wen* gradually gave way to the macho physicality of *wu*.[10]

His strong association with *wen* masculinity notwithstanding, Song also embodies what is outdated in *wu* masculinity. To be sure, Li may possess the most notable traits of the *wu* end of the masculine spectrum, namely physical robustness, he is by no means an authentic *wu* hero in the true sense of the word. In traditional Chinese narratives, the *wu* heroes always place brotherhood and mateship before romantic attachments. While it is common for *caizi* (the gifted scholar) to flirt and romance with *jiaren* (the beautiful woman) in traditional Chinese romantic narratives,[11] the *wu* hero, unlike the gallant *caizi*, is unmoved by beautiful women, shuns romantic involvements, and remains untainted both sexually and morally. Romance and beauties, after all, only distract the *wu* hero from the important social obligations which involve displaying extreme loyalty toward his teachers, his mates and friends, his family and the state. If this aspect of the *wen/wu* masculinities is taken into consideration, then Song, who displays extreme loyalty to his brother at the expense of a potential romance, is more *wu* than Li. When Li's mother Li Lan is dying, she asks Song to promise to her that he would look out for her son. This is what Song says: "Mama, don't you worry. I'll take care of Baldy Li for as long as I live. Even if I have one bowl of rice left, I'll let him have it, and if I have just one shirt left, I'll give it to him" (206). Indeed, Song is as good as his words. When the brothers find out that they both like Lin, Song thinks for Li more than he does for himself, which is why he refuses Lin even after her attempted suicide. Later when Li is temporarily financially broken, Song shares his own bowl of rice with him every day. Song's unsurpassed loyalty is perhaps matched only by the *wu* hero in the pre-modern Chinese culture.

Perceived from the *wen-wu* dyad, the downfall and eventual demise of Song Gang is thought-provoking. When Baldy Li shamelessly amasses fortunes, Song is left behind, clinging to "outdated" ideals of loyalty, sincerity, and emotional attachment. A man who is as good as his words has no place in a society where fraud and corruption pervade. Herein lies Yu Hua's most acrimonious critique of contemporary China as an increasingly self-indulgent and unhinged consumerist society which places materialism above moral goodness. The most telling testament is the National Virgin Beauty Competition which Li initiates. The three beauties who emerge victorious win by sexual bribes rather than fair play. Such an impetuous and corrupt society stands as a mockery of Song's honesty and integrity, the very traits that bring him down. Even after Li has become the town's tycoon, Song is still intent on making money through honest labor, refusing to turn to his brother even when he becomes downtrodden. Honest labor, however, only results in a broken back and a pair of damaged lungs. In the

changed socio-economic conditions, the traditional moral virtues have been rendered increasingly out of place.

The very traits that would have made Song masculine in the Chinese past now call into question his masculinity. Interestingly, throughout the novel, Song's gender identity is repeatedly questioned, demonstrating the undesirable nature of the soft masculinity he embodies. An early scenario in the novel sets the tone. After his father's death in the Cultural Revolution, Song goes to the countryside to live with his grandfather. Then, after Li's mother and Song's grandfather have both passed away, the two brothers start to live together again. Both, now in their late teens, have started to earn money from their first jobs in state-owned factories, and Song is the one who keeps their combined earnings. He shows Li where he stashes all the money:

> [. . .] He then bent over and unbuttoned his pants, revealing underwear stitched together from old scraps. There was a small pocket sewn on the inside of his underwear, and it was in this pocket that Song Gang carefully stashed their combined earnings. Baldy Li complimented Song Gang on the pocket and asked who had made it for him. Song Gang replied that he had stitched it himself, adding that he had also cut the pattern and sewn the underwear. Baldy Li expressed his admiration and asked, "Are you a man or a woman?"
>
> Song Gang laughed. "I also know how to knit a sweater" (217).

In this scenario, Song's male identity gets questioned for the first time, albeit with admiration. Indeed, in their life together, Song takes up the role conventionally assigned to women in a household. He cooks for Li and does all the cleaning, taking good care of his brother as he fulfills their mother's wish on her deathbed. When Li is officially appointed director of the factory where he works, Song even knits a sweater for him and is in turn complimented for being able to "do women's work" (239). This sweater also wins admiration from the women in Liu Town who have never seen a sweater with a sailboat embroidered on the front. They all crowd around Li to examine how it has been made, marveling at the delicacy and exquisiteness of the handiwork. When asked whose extraordinary skills have produced this sweater, Li responds proudly: "Song Gang. Aside from bearing children, Song Gang can do anything" (240). He goes on to counter the women with this question: "What are you women good for besides having children?" (240) Repeatedly, Li compares Song with women and concludes that the only advantage women have over his brother is that they can bear children.

In throwing Song's gender identity into doubt, Li effectively emasculates Song, relegating him to his Other. The metaphorical emasculation, sadly, is turned into reality when Song, hoaxed by Wandering Zhou during their trip in Hainan, undergoes a plastic surgery that gives him a pair of women's breasts – as part of a marketing strategy for a boobs cream.

> . . . Song Gang stood there like a model, without saying a word – his shirt unbuttoned, revealing his white bra and D-cup breasts. . . .
>
> The crowds started laughing uncontrollably, crowding around and staring at Song Gang curiously as though he were an alien. As Song Gang blushed with embarrassment, a petite young woman pinched his nipples. Song Gang angrily swatted her hand away, and one of the men reprimanded her, saying, "Where do you get off, thinking that you can fondle a man's sexual organs?"
>
> "You call this a sexual organ?" the woman asked in surprise.
>
> "As long as it is a breast and fondling it can bring on an orgasm, then it is a sexual organ." The man pointed at the woman's petite breasts and added, "I assume you consider these to be sexual organs, don't you?" (553)

At this point, the already feminized Song takes on an androgynous look, which repudiates his masculinity, symbolizing his eventual loss of manhood. Androgyny used to be an ideal among the Confucian literati, coming to particular prominence in the late sixteenth century toward the end of the Ming dynasty (Zhou, Song, Vitiello), embodied in the figure of *caizi* (the gifted scholar). The prevalence of the androgynous ideal has been attributed to Confucian ideologies and gender politics: "In China the realized person has been broadly defined as an achieved harmony of the full range of human traits and dispositions [. . .] the male has been free to pursue the task of realising his

personhood through the creation of an androgynous personality" (Hall and Ames 81). Starting from the late Ming dynasty, however, such an ideal gradually lost its appeal as anxiety about a "crisis of Confucian masculinity" began to grow (Vitiello 8–9). The anxiety revolving around Chinese masculinity continued into the Qing dynasty and reached its climax in the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries with China's demise, rendering androgyny an undesirable trait in Chinese men. Westernization and modernization since the early twentieth century only intensified the crisis of masculinity. Under the influence of the dominant Western notion of masculinity, male androgyny is increasingly detested in the Chinese context. In view of this history, Song Gang's androgyny, which relegates him further to China's pre-modern past, prefigures his coming fate.

When Song puts aside his dignity to promote the Boobs cream in order to make money to give his wife a good life, Lin Hong is having sexual affairs with his brother. Lin remains a devoted wife to Song for 20 years until Li's intrusion. Song's response to the affair stands as the ultimate testament to the impasse where the traditional culture finds itself. Upon learning his wife's affair with his brother, Song decides to end his own life to make room for the couple. His death wish is for Li to take good care of Lin. After making sure that he has settled his wife into an easy life, Song commits suicide at a train track. Indeed, death seems to be the only viable solution for Song, a self-sacrificing altruist whose loyalty toward others surpasses that toward himself. Song's last gesture before departure serves as the best footnote to the way he has lived: he makes sure that his face mask is on out of the concern that "his lung illness would be transmitted to the mortician" (600). Song is, so to speak, the archetype of the traditional Chinese values that have been rendered increasingly obsolete, and hence irrelevant, in modern times. His demise symbolizes the eventual displacement of traditional Chinese masculinity, a combination of *wen* and *wu*, crushed by the new cultural logic of the contemporary world. Ultimately, it is his Confucian ideals of morality, characterized by integrity and self-sacrifice, that compromises him in a materialistic Chinese society of the late twentieth century.

Conclusion

Yu Hua's best-selling novel *Brothers* uses the life trajectories of two stepbrothers to dramatize the social and historical transformations China has undergone in the latter half of the twentieth century. Amid the dynamic interplay of modernization and globalization, the country's moral outlooks and gender conceptions are also being reconfigured drastically. The essay looks beyond the female body to explore Chinese masculinities which can be read as allegories for the radical historical transformations that have turned China into what it is today. Masculinities are revealed as historically contingent, produced by the ideologies of the socio-economic systems in which the male subjects find themselves. Protagonist Baldy Li embodies what is called predatory masculinity, which is the hegemonic model in the late twentieth-century Chinese society. Characterized by chauvinistic individualism, unscrupulous aggression, and outrageous audacity, it is a product of the country's newly emerging market economy. On the other hand, there are alternative models which reflect the persistent influence of the Chinese tradition (Shen 221–22). The type of masculinity embodied in protagonist Song Gang, on the other hand, is deeply nostalgic and harks back to the Chinese tradition. Encompassing outdated traits from both *wen* and *wu* masculinities, soft masculinity, as it is termed in this essay, comprises highly regarded values that are rendered increasingly irrelevant in modern times, signaling the eventual collapse of traditional Confucian values under the new cultural logic.

Yu Hua, however, applauds neither model, not least because neither of the protagonists winds up well. The brothers' bond, forged in the shared trauma of the Cultural Revolution, is fractured by the greed of the market. The bond is ultimately broken up with Song's suicide. Upon hearing the news of his brother's death, Li, who is in bed with Lin Hong, is taken aback, and subsequently loses his sexual virility. The fact that Baldy Li, despite his rise in financial terms and social status, eventually ends up impotent suggests a deep ambivalence toward this model of masculinity, repudiating, to a certain extent, not only the myth of Li's ascent but also the viability of the hegemonic model. Such a tragic-comic ending points to an uneasy truth – that both models of masculinity are deeply flawed, albeit in their own ways. Eventually, masculinity can be viewed as

an intriguing and contested site not only of competing values but also of contrasting socio-economic systems. Yu Hua does not simply critique the Cultural Revolution; nor does he celebrate the market-based economy. Both systems deformed the masculine subject: while the Cultural Revolution emasculated through political violence; the reform era masculinizes only through money and spectacle. Masculinity, therefore, can serve as a theoretical lens through which to critique both eras. Since neither the ideologically rigid Maoist system nor the unbridled market economy allows for a healthy and humanistic expression of masculinity, it may be further argued that like morality, masculinity is compromised and eventually becomes a casualty in China's relentless historical transition.

It has now been almost two decades since *Brothers* was first published. Changing material circumstances have continued to shape gendered constructs. In the rapidly developing and highly diversified postmodern society of the present-day China, masculinities have also been increasingly diversified and hybridized. One might wonder whether the kind of masculinity that helped Baldy Li thrive in the 1980s and 90s still remains the hegemonic model in the 2020s. As the country's market economy develops into its fourth decade, a more refined corporate masculinity has emerged to replace the predatory model to become the dominant norm. Nonetheless, there are masculine traits that have remained consistent since the early-2000s. While masculinity and male anxiety revolved around political power and fame in the traditional Chinese culture, they have become increasingly intertwined with business acumen and monetary power, a product of socio-historical changes amid the continued process of modernization and globalization.

Notes

1. By the year 2019, Yu's works had been published in 38 countries and translated into 35 different languages (Rabut and Pino 99). *Xiong Di* (*Brothers*) is Yu Hua's own personal favorite among all his literary works. The novel was first translated into French in 2008 and Italian in 2009, with English and Spanish versions coming after, followed by Hungarian, German and Dutch versions (Rabut and Pino 101).
2. Serious literary critics lashed out at Yu Hua for producing what may be called "a trashy, Hollywood-style portrait of the country," or "a tear-jerking soap opera" (Barboza). In his conversation with Minhong Yu, Yu Hua reflects on the criticisms launched upon his novel in China and speaks very proudly of the recognition he receives overseas (Yu and Yu). There are, however, also criticisms concerning the novel's style, contents and morality that echo critical responses in China (see, for instance, Lovell).
3. *New York Times* author Jess Row comments that the novel "begins as a sentimental family-epic-cum-romantic-comedy" but "morphs into broad historical satire" in the second volume. Austin Ramzy concludes in a review carried in *Time* that "no other literary works can be sharper or more savage than *Brothers* concerning the portraits of contemporary China."
4. For discussions of female masculinity, refer to Halberstam.
5. Yu Hua is aware of the politically sensitive nature of the subject matter, especially his descriptions of the Cultural Revolution in Volume 1. As he himself admits: "I stipulate in all my contracts that my manuscripts can't be touched editorially; not a word can be taken out. That's because there's a lot of politically sensitive material in there" (quoted from Lovell "Finding a Place" 25).
6. The Cultural Revolution was a formative experience for Yu Hua as a writer. As he himself notes in an interview: "The Cultural Revolution was my formative experience, from the age of seven to seventeen, which of course would leave a significant impact" (Zhang and Yao 81).
7. Since its formulation, the concept has been usefully applied in a wide range of disciplines, but it has also attracted criticisms. For a useful analysis of the major critiques directed at the concept, see Connell and Messerschmidt 836–45.
8. The Inaugural National Virgin Beauty Competition is depicted in the novel as an absurd event. It is believed that the competition is meant to insinuate the "beauty-pageant fever" that China was stuck in around the turn of the century. In the translators' preface, the translators point out that a few years before the Olympics, China was in the grip of a pre-Olympics beauty-pageant fever. In September of 2003, for instance, a national beauty pageant was held on Hainan Island as a prelude to China's first time hosting the Miss World competition two months later, and they present the event depicted in the novel as "an echo of the Miss Artificial Beauty competition that was held in December 2004, while Yu Hua was writing his novel" (IX).
9. The impact of modernization on the Chinese conception of masculinity differs radically from the West. While it has been argued by ultra-conservatives in the West that modernization has led to "a feminizing process that leaves men

soft, complacent and cowardly" (Forth 236), in the context of China, the supremacy of *wen* masculinity and its soft characteristics has increasingly given way to an emphasis on physical robustness and macho power in men.

10. Historically, the *wen/wu* controversy can be traced further back. During the early years of the Qing dynasty, Confucian scholars, when analyzing the downfall of the Ming dynasty, attacked the educational system prioritizing *wen* over *wu* since the Song dynasty. The consequence of such an educational system, according to the scholars, was the feminization of the Confucian literati and their resultant inability to carry out many duties for the nation (Huang 1). Yan Yuan (1635–1704), a renowned scholar who was an outspoken advocate of radical educational reform, proposed and championed a reversal of the primacy of *wen* over *wu*.
11. The figure of *caizi* (the gifted scholar) is the protagonist of traditional Chinese romances. Despite his physical fragility and delicate constitution, he is still portrayed as a desirable male in romantic tales:"Despite the association with effeminacy this image recalls for today's (Chinese and Western) audience, it embodies all the desirable masculine qualities in the literary discourse of ideal heterosexual love in traditional China" (Song viii).

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